Do Different Choice Contexts Shape Children's Expectations for Selective Comforting Among Friends?

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Introduction

Social relationships shape children's expectations for selective prosocial behavior. By middle childhood, children's reasoning about prosocial obligations between friends versus strangers varies according to the type and severity of need involved (Miller et al., 1990).

Around 4 years, children expect friends to favor one another when dividing resources (Liberman & Shaw, 2017; Olson & Spelke, 2008). But expectations about other prosocial behaviors—such as comforting, which differs in type and severity—may have a different trajectory.

Children's expectations of partiality may also depend on how a scenario is framed. Friends and non-friends alike may be expected to aid an injured person, even if children assume that people usually choose to favor aiding friends over a non-friend.

- Do children expect friends to selectively comfort one another?
- If so, do these expectations vary across decision contexts?

Methods

Study 1: 72 4- to 6-year-olds
Study 2: 63 4- to 6-year-olds (72 planned)

Practice Trials:

Children twice practiced showing how a single, unpaired character comforts a hurt protagonist

Test Trials:

6 trials, each featuring unique characters and introduction/comforting scenes

Protagonist Introduction

Friendly Interaction: The Protagonist has a friendly, familiar interaction with the Friend, instead of sitting alone

No interaction: The Protagonist engages a fun solo activity, instead of joining the Non-friend

Test Phase: Children indicate who will comfort the protagonist (**Study 1**) or whom the protagonist will comfort (**Study 2**)

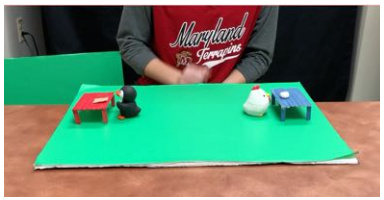
On each of 6 trials…

Familiarization Phase

Protagonist Introduction

Friendly Interaction with Friend

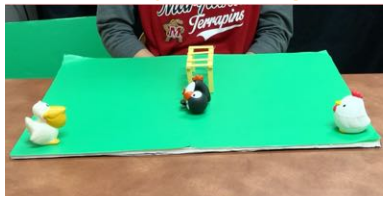
No Interaction with Non-Friend



Test Trial

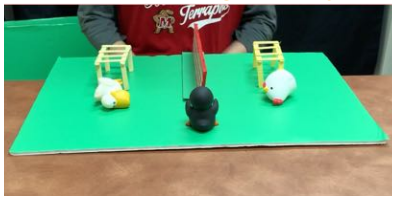
Study 1

Who will comfort the Protagonist?

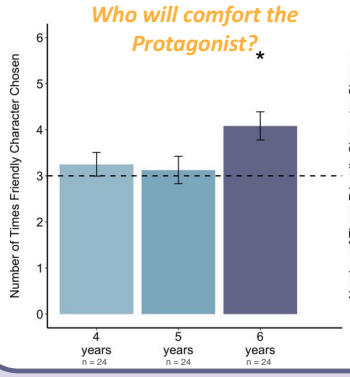


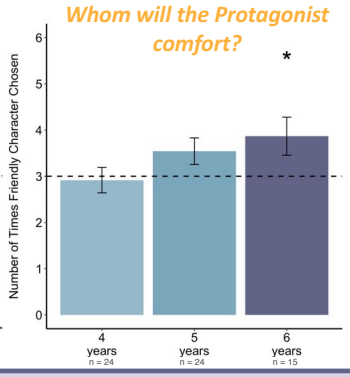
Study 2

Whom will the Protagonist comfort?



Results





Do children expect friendly characters to selectively comfort one another?

Yes, by 6 years.

Do children's expectations vary across decision contexts?

No.

Experiment:
b = 1.2, z = 0.81, p = 0.35
Experiment x Age:
b = -0.02, z = -0.91, p = 0.36

* < 0.05; Error bars denote standard errors

Discussion

In both studies, children's choices reveal expectations for selective comforting between friends by 6 years.

- This is notably later than expectations for selective resource division. Might the greater severity of need have attenuated younger children's expectation of partiality?

Children's choices appear similar across decision contexts:

- Counter to our prediction, expectations of partiality did not emerge earlier when reflecting on a Protagonist's relative concern for each of two injured characters (Study 2), compared to reflecting on the relative concern that different characters would have for an injured Protagonist (Study 1).
- Data collection is ongoing for Study 2's 6-year-olds, so the overall comparison between decision contexts remains preliminary.

Future Directions

To explore the possibility that younger children had expectations of partiality, we are now coding further details of their responses, such as latency and how they act out comforting with the dolls.

Our relationship manipulation was based on a single behavioral demonstration of affiliation – we did not explicitly label the affiliated characters as "friends." This term means different things to children of different ages (Furman & Bierman, 1983). For what ages might verbal labels enhance expectations of partiality in comforting behavior?

References

Furman, W. & Bierman, K.L. (1983). Developmental changes in young children's conceptions of friendship. *Child Development, 54*(3), 549-556.
Liberman, Z. & Shaw, A. (2017). Children use partial resource sharing as a cue to friendship. *Journal of Experimental Psychology, 159*, 96-109.
Miller, J.G., Bersoff, D.M., & Harwood, R.L. (1990). Perceptions of social responsibilities in India and in the United States. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 58*(1), 33-47.
Olson, K.R. & Spelke, E.S. (2008). Foundations of cooperation in young children. *Cognition, 108*(1), 222-231.